



UNLESS YOU HAVE been living under a rock, chances are that you have heard and read the term ‘superfoods’ being bandied about over the past few years, especially during the pandemic. According to Google trends 2022, search queries for the term ‘superfoods’ has been growing steadily since 2009. It had an interest value of 7 out of 100 in 2009 and this has gone up to 70 out of 100 in 2022.

But what exactly are superfoods? There is no single definition simply because it is more of a marketing term rather than a scientific one. “The definition of superfood is extremely vague. According to me, a superfood is a food that matches two criteria. The first is that it provides a particular nutrient in huge amounts, much more than in any other food. For example, cranberries have more antioxidants than any other food and so it becomes a superfood. The second criterion is that a particular food is so packed with nutrients that it almost becomes like a pill in the form of food. It gives you a little bit of this and a little bit of that but together it gives you a whole lot,” says Kavita Devgan, a Delhi-based nutritionist and author of books such as *Fix it with Food*. For instance, beetroot meets the second criterion as it gives you iron, vitamin A, soluble fibre and multiple other trace minerals that the body doesn’t get otherwise, adds Devgan.

Delhi-based preventive health practitioner, Dr Shikha Sharma, Founder of Nutri-Health,

says that a superfood has therapeutic qualities. “I consider any food that you can consume and which has therapeutic properties beyond just its vitamin and mineral content as a superfood. For instance, *amla* (Indian gooseberry) is considered a superfood in modern times and in ancient times it was called a *rasayan*. A *rasayan* is something that has healing properties. *Amla* is one of the most important *rasayans* in ayurvedic literature. Another example is *tulsi* (holy basil). In terms of vitamins and minerals it is rather normal. Yet it has nearly 40 healing properties. So I would consider it a super healer or a superfood.”

Amla is a rich source of vitamin C and half an *amla* a day takes care of all your vitamin C requirements. *Tulsi*, on the other hand, is a source of vitamin C and zinc but has several health benefits including boosting your immunity, controlling blood sugar and blood pressure and improving your lipid profile. It is also supposed to have antidepressant qualities and counters psychological stress. Sharma recommends having *amla* as a part of a smoothie or vegetable juice and *tulsi* as part of your tea. “Avoid *amla murabba* or candy as that is just sugar. Chewing *tulsi* leaves is also not recommended,” says Sharma.

While superfoods are packed with nutrients, vitamins, minerals and antioxidants, they are not miracle foods. “Superfoods without having essential foods is like having a super car without tyres. Meaningless. You can have as many superfoods but if you don’t have a good healthy diet, it is of no use,” says Azhar Ali Sayed, a holistic health coach and author of *Eat your cake, lose your weight*. Agrees Devgan: “The concept of superfoods should be taken with a pinch of salt. They are not a cure-all. Every food is good for us if we eat it by